

RSS



BJP ACCUSES CONGRESS OF MINORITY APPEASEMENT IN ELECTION TIME

The ATS Flip-flop

It's probably a textbook case into how not to conduct an investigation. Seeking to link the arrested army officer, Lt-Colonel Srikant Prasad Purohit, to not just the Malegaon bombing which killed six persons, but the February 2007 Samjhauta train bombings that killed 68 persons, the Maharashtra public prosecutor told a Nasik court that Purohit may have pilfered nearly 60 kg of RDX from a military depot to use in the train blast. Purohit gave a portion of the explosives to one of the suspects and threw the rest into the Jhelum, the prosecutor said. A day later, the Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) retracted the statement.

For the army, which tracks even a spent cartridge during practice firing sessions, even the thought that the accused officer could have obtained such an absurdly vast quantity of explosives is simply unthinkable. For starters, the army does not use RDX but Plastic

Explosive Kirkee or PEK. Besides, there is no way so much explosive could have gone missing without triggering off an inquiry, says the army. "We are shocked at the conduct of the investigations," says a senior army official. Even a cursory reading of the tragic train bombing would have told the ATS that fire-bombs with gasoline, and not RDX, were used in the blasts.



LT-COLONEL PUROHIT

The damage had already been done. In trying to link the accused to other blasts, the ATS may have ended up contradicting the Intelligence Bureau assessments that the Samjhauta bombings were planned and executed by Pakistani nationals. In March last year, India also handed over a suspect's photograph to Pakistani authorities. The question is whether the ATS has enough evidence against the Abhinav Bharat group accused of planting the bomb in Malegaon or is simply buying time by linking them up with the other blasts.

by Sandeep Unnithan

any religion. He also said that not hanging Afzal Guru (convicted by Supreme Court in 2001 Parliament attack) and sympathies for the terrorists killed and arrested following the Batla House encounter only went on to prove the Congress's appeasement agenda and votebank politics.

The Congress and several of its allies, including Railways Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav and Samajwadi Party leader Amar Singh, had repeatedly questioned the authenticity of the encounter at Batla House, located in the middle of the Muslim locality of Jamia Nagar. Senior Congress leader Kapil Sibal had visited the area and supported the demand for a judicial probe into the encounter. Finally, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had to step in by putting his foot down on the demand for a judicial inquiry.

The BJP is also going out of its way to make Batla House and Guru's case its major poll planks. The party, in its manifesto for Delhi Assembly elections, has promised early implementation of the court's verdict if it comes to power. "Why are people accusing us of appeasing the majority? Even if we are, it is high time somebody did it. The Congress has been going out of its way to appease the Muslims. It is thanks to them that India has to tackle the menace of tens of thousands of Bangladeshi citizens. The population profile of the North-east has changed. They have a free run of the country and are eating into the job share of Indians. Somebody has to speak up for the majority," said a BJP worker.

Rajnath went on to warn that if Congress-coined phrases like "Hindu terrorism" and "Muslim terrorism" continued and actual acts of terrorism not contained, it would take the country towards a civil war. He even attended the Panipat conclave where the Sangh Parivar decided to organise a mass mobilisation campaign for the Malegaon accused. On the eve of elections, market value of terrorism goes up, and truth lies orphaned outside the competitive rhetoric. ■